

Prologue:

The Kingdom of Blessed Isles was in mourning.

King Ignatius Valyrian Thorne, the beloved ruler of the Blessed Isles was dead.

One day, he had stood before his people, strong and healthy as ever. The next, he was found in his chambers cold and limp, with no one by his side.

When the royal physician arrived, he offered no explanation. The only thing he could muster was a weak condolence to the family. No sickness had plagued him, no wound marked his body.

The room was heavy with sorrow. The wailings of his widow pierced through the room. The princess, sobbing silently, comforting her mother. The palace help teared up. He had treated them with respect and kindness that they would never forget.

Whispers of foul play spread faster than wildfire.

The kingdom mourned its king, but beneath the grief, simmered uncertainty.

In a fortnight's time, the Princess Elvira would have her coronation and ascent the throne, being crowned the Queen of The Blessed Isles.

The sole heir, the future of the kingdom, and the woman I had sworn my life to protect.

My name matters little for I am simply her knight, her shield and her sword.

Yet, before I became any of these, I was merely a boy growing up within the castle grounds alongside a young princess.

Elvira and I spent our childhood together.

We snuck into libraries we were forbidden to enter, pretended to sword fight using wooden sticks in the courtyard and dreamed of adventures beyond these walls.

As the years passed, those childish affections became something deeper.

Something dangerous.

I loved her.

I had loved her for as long as I could remember and despite every attempt to bury those feelings beneath duty and honour, they never left me.

I knew these foolish desires could never be of fruition for she was of royal descent, and I was not.

I was the son of a Baron. Our family had pledged allegiance to the royal family, swearing to serve as their sword and shield. Though I was of noble blood, the court would never approve of a union between our families- politics, they would proclaim.

So, I buried my feelings where no one could find them.

I could not have her hand, but I could give her my sword.

So, I swore to protect her honour and her life.

Even if the price was my own.

The Blessed Isles, though a prosperous kingdom, had a social disparity.

At its heart stood the castle, where the royal family governed.

Beyond its walls lay the High District, home to nobles, scholars and wealthy families whose influence helped shape the realm.

The Merchant's Row was where most townspeople lived. A maze of markets, guild halls and trade houses where coin spoke louder than titles.

Beneath it all, festered The Dregs.

A lawless place that reeked of poverty, crime and death.

If any rumours existed within the kingdom, it was likely to be birthed there.

The kingdom held another prejudice as old as its walls.

Magic.

For generations, witches had been feared and reviled.

The Temple preached that magic corrupted all who wielded it. Many among the clergy believed witches should be hunted to extinction.

The people believed witches to be the servants of evil.

Those who practiced the craft either hid their abilities or fled far beyond the kingdoms reach.

Yet with the king dead and rumours spreading, certainty had become a luxury I could no longer afford.

Official investigations yielded nothing.

One of my squires had been gathering information from informants throughout the kingdom. Most returned with little more than rumours and speculation.

This one returned pale and shaken. He requested a private audience and insisted that what he had learned could not wait.

I still remember the look in his eyes.

*Fear.*

The kind that lingers after witnessing something one was never meant to see.

"My lord," he said, glancing over his shoulder. "I believe there are those who intend to disrupt the princess's coronation. Powerful people. I heard talk of a guild and-"

The sharp whistle of an arrow cut through the air.

A sickening thud followed.

For a moment neither of us moved.

Then he collapsed, dead before he struck the ground.

Panic erupted around us as guards rushed to secure the area, but the assassin had vanished.

The only thing my squire left behind was a fragment of information.

A guild. No name, or location.

Only the certainty that someone wanted the truth buried.

And if they were willing to kill one of my men to keep their secret, then the threat against Elvira was far greater than I had imagined.

I was desperate,

The only path that remained was the mercenary guilds. Organizations that thrived in the shadows between legality and crime. Information brokers, smugglers, fixers- anything one could desire, so long as their coin purse was heavy.

If someone had orchestrated the king's death, chances were that a guild had heard whispers of it.

The problem was finding the right one.

Many operated under the nose of the kingdom, never publicly advertising their dealings. Certainly, none that would willingly reveal themselves to a knight of the Crown.

Yet the squire's last words haunted me.

*A conspiracy.*

Somewhere within the shadows of The Dregs was a lead.

If someone truly sought to dispose of Elvira before her coronation...

Then I had only fourteen days.

Fourteen days to expose and put a stop to their schemes.

Or watch the woman I loved meet the same fate as her father.